

THE EXTERIOR

Before the advent of high-strength metal alloys and reliable welding techniques, the most effective way of making a light, rigid airframe was to build it in wood and brace it with wire. There was nothing simple or crude about such structures, which employed hundreds of intricate metal fittings and carefully selected lumber. The wings of the Blériot XI were designed to be detached and stacked alongside the fuselage for road and rail transport.

1. Manufacturer's data plate 2. Walnut propeller and I-section steel engine mounts 3. Bungee chord suspension 4. Single-ignition spark plug 5. Undercarriage fitting, shaped to minimize weight 6. Split-pinned stays 7. Wing fabric, showing reinforcement over ribs 8. Wide washers under lightweight nuts and bolts prevent lumber from being crushed 9. Wing-warping (roll control) bellcrank 10. Elevator control horn 11. Tip elevator and tailplane bracing rod 12. Rudder horns and hinges

